Ontology Laundering

A Diagnostic Theory of Semantic Anchor Replacement Under Legitimacy Pressure

Those anchors must change when evidence, conditions, or legitimate purposes change.

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Abstract

Institutions depend on revisable semantic anchors: definitions, classifications, measures, precedents, evidentiary rules, and authority relations that connect claims to observation and consequence. Those anchors must change when evidence, conditions, or legitimate purposes change. They can also be changed in ways that preserve procedural legitimacy while concealing weakened correspondence, displaced accountability, or asymmetric advantage.

This paper develops **ontology laundering** as a candidate diagnostic for the latter pattern. Ontology laundering is not every semantic change, mistaken definition, political disagreement, institutional failure, or disputed measurement. It is a materially consequential alteration of an interpretive system whose provenance, authority, evidentiary basis, consequences, or contestability are obscured in a way that makes a previously visible conflict appear resolved, admissible, or authoritative.

The framework separates deliberate laundering from emergent drift, negligence, adaptive revision, and good-faith disagreement. It models an ontology version, a change event, and a multidimensional risk profile; provides tests for vocabulary drift, metric substitution, procedural displacement, model and statistical laundering, synthetic evidence, consensus closure, and legitimacy recursion; and identifies false-positive controls. The paper integrates Meaning as Binding, Semantic Debt, Governed Semantic Cartography, Authority Laundering Theory, Reasoning by Way of Receipts, Governance Coverage Gaps, the Governed Meaning Base, and the universal GSM.

The result is a research and governance specification, not a finding that any named institution has engaged in laundering. No external case research was conducted. The framework requires exact change custody, competing explanations, asymmetric-effect analysis, contradiction channels, outcome evidence, and explicit limits before it can support a bounded diagnosis.

Source, Evidence, and Standing

This is an AI-assisted integrated edition derived from one exact author manuscript. The custody and comparison manifest is
`work/paper-saturation-v1/evidence/ontology-laundering/integration-custody-manifest.v0.1.json`,
SHA-256
`C7C008ADBC74B97B887C44E1F2E91ADFC6DAF9DB01709AB4F90E9603E5C4D8D4`.
The source remains unchanged.

The name, central mechanism, laundering surfaces, legitimacy-recursion thesis, resistance mechanisms, and original proof boundary are author material. The formal model, intent-neutral classifications, diagnostic protocol, corpus interfaces, tests, and decisions added here are AI editorial or synthetic candidates until the author adopts them. No external research was conducted, and no institutional allegation is made.

1. The Problem

Most accounts of institutional corruption assume that a stable rule or meaning has been violated. A record is falsified, a procedure bypassed, an authority forged, or evidence concealed. These cases remain legible because the semantic anchors by which the act is judged still have force.

Ontology laundering concerns a different failure surface: the anchors themselves change. A word is broadened, an outcome is replaced by a proxy, a verification practice becomes a credential, an authority validates its own standards, or an exclusion rule removes the observations by which the arrangement could fail. The change may be formally approved and internally coherent. The question is whether the transition remains visibly and corrigibly coupled to its declared purpose, evidence, and affected parties.

The theory is useful only if it can distinguish legitimate revision from semantic change that hides its own burden.

2. Definitions

An **ontology** here is not a complete metaphysics. It is a bounded institutional interpretation system:

$$O_t = (V_t, R_t, A_t, P_t, M_t),$$

where V_t is vocabulary, R_t typed relations and classifications, A_t semantic anchors, P_t interpretive and admissibility procedures, and M_t measures or proxies at version t.

A **semantic anchor** is a governed relation connecting a symbol or classification to some combination of observation, authority, prior usage, procedure, consequence, and revision condition. An anchor is never perfect access to reality. It is an inspectable correspondence claim with a bounded observation regime.

An **ontology change** is a transition $O_t \to O_{t+1}$. It may be corrective, adaptive, contested, negligent, captured, or deliberately deceptive.

Ontology laundering is a candidate classification for a materially consequential ontology change that:

1. changes what can be asserted, measured, admitted, refused, or authorized;
2. obscures or misrepresents the change, its authority, evidentiary burden, beneficiaries, losses, or alternatives; and
3. converts that opacity into apparent legitimacy, closure, or exemption from contradiction.

The definition does not require an advance finding of malicious intent. Intent is a separate evidentiary question.

3. Legitimate Revision and Laundering Risk

Semantic stability is not semantic immobility. A healthy institution must correct obsolete classifications, harmful language, inaccurate measures, new evidence, and changed operating conditions. Legitimate revision can be controversial and still be legitimate.

A revision has stronger standing when it preserves:

- exact predecessor and successor definitions;
- declared change authority and scope;
- stated reasons and supporting evidence;
- mappings between old and new terms;
- known incompatibilities and migration effects;
- affected-party and conflict disclosures;
- admissible contradiction and appeal;
- external outcome checks;
- reversible or compensating paths where feasible; and
- revision when the new anchor fails.

Ontology laundering risk rises when these are absent, especially when absence benefits the authority responsible for the change. No single missing field proves laundering.

4. The Ontology Change Record

Represent a proposed change as:

$$\Delta_t = (O_t, O_{t+1}, p, u, a, q, e, b, x, k),$$

where p is the proposer, u the authorizing authority, a the affected anchors, q the declared rationale, e supporting and counterevidence, b beneficiaries and burdened parties, x expected and observed effects, and k contest, compatibility, and rollback provisions.

The record should bind both semantic and operational effects. A definition change can alter eligibility, safety classifications, funding, moderation, legal consequence, scientific inclusion, or model behavior. A formally complete receipt proves only that the recorded transition occurred under the recorded process. It does not prove that the new ontology is true, fair, complete, or legitimate.

5. A Risk Vector, Not an Oracle

Ontology laundering should not be reduced to one accusation score. Use a profile:

$$L(\Delta_t) = (o, c, d, r, s, g, v),$$

where:

- o is change opacity;
- c is authority concentration or conflict;
- d is decoupling from declared evidence or outcomes;
- r is loss of reversibility or compatibility;
- s is suppression of contradiction or appeal;
- g is proxy gaming or metric displacement; and
- v is self-validation or legitimacy recursion.

Each dimension requires a declared scale, evidence source, uncertainty, and reviewer. The vector supports comparison and inquiry; it does not create an automatic verdict. Different domains may weight dimensions differently, and some necessary changes are irreversible without being laundered.

6. Classification Without Premature Intent Attribution

The same observed pattern can have different causes. A review should distinguish at least:

- **documented legitimate revision:** material change with visible authority, evidence, consequences, and contest;
- **contested revision:** visible change with unresolved value or evidence disputes;
- **under-governed drift:** change accumulated without adequate custody or review;
- **negligent distortion:** foreseeable semantic or outcome damage ignored or inadequately tested;
- **strategic laundering candidate:** opacity or closure plausibly used to secure legitimacy or advantage; and

- **deliberate laundering finding:** intent supported by evidence independent of the resulting pattern.

Only the last category makes an intent finding. Outcome, incentive, and asymmetry may justify investigation but do not substitute for evidence of intent.

7. Mechanism Families

The source identifies several mechanism families. They are best treated as testable patterns.

Vocabulary drift occurs when a term's extension, threshold, or normative force changes without adequate versioning or migration. Drift may be adaptive; risk appears when material consequences are hidden behind continuity of wording.

Metric substitution occurs when a proxy becomes the operational objective and failure against the original purpose is no longer visible. Proxy use is unavoidable in many domains; the test is whether the proxy's limits, gaming surface, and outcome relation remain inspectable.

Procedural displacement occurs when completing an admissibility process is treated as sufficient evidence for the underlying claim. Procedure can warrant a decision without establishing truth.

Model laundering occurs when a model's assumptions, data, uncertainty, fitness domain, or failure record are obscured while the output gains authority beyond demonstrated support. Model transparency alone is insufficient: privacy, security, proprietary restrictions, and comprehension costs may require controlled access and independent evaluation.

Statistical laundering concerns analytic choices that produce a materially misleading but procedurally defensible result. Endpoint, denominator, exclusion, aggregation, uncertainty, and multiplicity choices require domain-specific evidence; their mere presence is not laundering.

Synthetic evidence laundering occurs when generated, transformed, relabeled, or recursively cited material is presented with stronger independence or empirical standing than it possesses.

8. Consensus and Legitimacy Recursion

Consensus can summarize convergent evidence, coordinate action under uncertainty, or record professional judgment. It is not inherently a laundering mechanism. Risk appears when the existence of consensus replaces the evidence for the claim, dissent is excluded from the evidence process by definition, or the same authority controls membership, standards, validation, and appeal.

Legitimacy recursion occurs when an institution's authority is justified primarily by outputs, credentials, models, or procedures whose validity depends on that same authority. Some recursion is unavoidable in constitutional and professional

systems. The diagnostic question is whether independent constraint, plural review, contest, and revision can enter the loop.

9. Civilization-Scale Ontology Capture

The source proposes that mutually reinforcing institutions can converge on a self-protective semantic structure. This is a large hypothesis, not an established result. Apparent cross-domain convergence may instead reflect shared evidence, law, infrastructure, culture, coordination needs, market concentration, or observer selection.

The hypothesis becomes researchable only with explicit domains, time windows, anchor changes, dependency relations, counterexamples, external outcome measures, and alternate causal models. "Civilization-scale capture" should not function as an explanation that absorbs all disagreement.

10. Diagnostic Protocol

For a bounded suspected change:

1. identify the exact predecessor and successor ontology versions;
2. enumerate changed terms, relations, measures, procedures, and consequences;
3. identify proposer, authority, affected parties, and declared purpose;
4. reconstruct evidence, counterevidence, uncertainty, and excluded material;
5. test compatibility, migration, appeal, and revision paths;
6. compare observed outcomes against the old and new declared purposes;
7. identify benefits, burdens, conflicts, and asymmetric enforcement;
8. score the risk vector with uncertainty and reviewer disagreement;
9. test benign and legitimate alternate explanations;
10. classify the case without inferring intent beyond the evidence; and
11. issue a revisable finding bound to exact sources and observation limits.

The protocol can return
`INSUFFICIENT_EVIDENCE`, `LEGITIMATE_REVISION`,
`CONTESTED_REVISION`, `UNDER_GOVERNED_DRIFT`, `LAUNDERING_RISK`,
or a more specific finding authorized by the domain. Refusal to classify is a valid result.

11. GMB and GSM Integration

The **Governed Meaning Base (GMB)** can retain ontology versions, exact definitions, source bindings, authority, rationale, evidence and counterevidence, affected parties, conflict disclosures, compatibility maps, findings, appeals, and revision lineage. Inclusion in GMB is custody and navigability, not truth or standing.

The universal **GSM** can type relations such as `REVISES`, `REPLACES_ANCHOR`, `USES_PROXY`,
`AUTHORIZED_BY`, `SUPPORTED_BY`, `CONTESTED_BY`, `BURDENS`, `BENEFITS`, `OBSERVED_UNDER`,
and `REVERSES`. Lexical similarity and temporal succession do not prove replacement, causation, or laundering.

Independent witnesses can share data, incentives, methods, or failure modes. Their independence must be represented rather than presumed.

12. Corpus Integration

Meaning as Binding explains why a semantic relation can constrain downstream action. **Semantic Debt** describes unresolved semantic obligations and accumulated divergence. **Governed Semantic Cartography** supplies versioned mappings and contested regions. **Authority Laundering Theory** addresses borrowed or obscured authority; ontology laundering instead concerns the interpretive substrate by which authority and evidence are understood.

Reasoning by Way of Receipts supplies custody and bounded inference without turning a receipt into truth. **Governance Coverage Gaps** asks which semantic or effect paths escape the declared governance membrane. These are interfaces, not identity mergers.

13. Realization Funnel

$$\begin{aligned} & P \\ & \to S \\ & \to CM_1 \\ & \to CM_2 \\ & \to IC \\ & \to IR \\ & \to E \\ & \to R \end{aligned}.$$

- **Possibility:** enumerate legitimate revision, drift, negligence, capture, and laundering models.
- **Specification:** define the ontology record, risk dimensions, classifications, evidence, and limits.
- **CM1:** retain admissible diagnostic configurations, including costly, plural, or inconclusive ones.
- **CM2:** prefer configurations that preserve custody, contradiction, privacy, due process, independence, and outcome coupling.
- **IC:** select an Instance Constitution or Instance Configuration for one bounded domain study.

- **IR:** produce an Instance Realization or Implementation Realization of the registry, review process, and reporting surface.
- **Evidence:** test cases, controls, reviewer agreement, outcome correspondence, false positives, appeals, and revisions.
- **Revision:** amend definitions, weights, classifications, and governance under explicit lineage.

This paper reaches Specification and proposes CM1/CM2 criteria. It does not select a domain IC, produce an IR, or validate the diagnostic.

In this funnel, IR denotes the realization stage. It does not rename the distinct Intermediate Representation sense used by MCIR and other compiler-oriented corpus terms.

14. Evaluation Program

A serious evaluation should include documented legitimate revisions, failed but good-faith revisions, under-governed drift, known deceptive changes, ambiguous cases, and negative controls. Reviewers should code cases independently before seeing the proposed classification. Measures should include anchor-change reconstruction, evidence completeness, inter-rater agreement, false-positive and false-negative rates, sensitivity to missing custody, appeal outcomes, outcome prediction, and performance against simpler explanations.

Privacy, confidentiality, source protection, and security may limit disclosure. The protocol should distinguish justified restricted access from unverifiable secrecy and should never require harmful publication merely to earn legitimacy.

Consequential Semantic-Change Diagnostic

Across the completed P1 corpus, Ontology Laundering is the **diagnostic for consequential changes to terms, classifications, anchors, measures, and admissibility rules whose authority, evidence, burdens, alternatives, or effects are obscured so that conflict appears resolved or legitimacy appears inherited**. It is not a label for every semantic change, political disagreement, model use, proxy, consensus, or disliked outcome.

- **Adjacent work:** *Meaning as Binding*
  Supplies: How semantic relations constrain downstream interpretation and action.
  Ontology-laundering boundary: Laundering risk becomes consequential when changed meanings alter bindings.

- **Adjacent work:** *Semantic Debt*
  Supplies: Unresolved semantic obligations, divergence, and future change burden.
  Ontology-laundering boundary: Under-governed change can accumulate debt without meeting the laundering diagnosis.

- **Adjacent work:** *Governed Semantic Cartography*
  Supplies: Versioned maps, contested regions, projections, and traversal.
  Ontology-laundering boundary: Cartography reconstructs predecessor and successor semantic territory.
- **Adjacent work:** *Authority Laundering Theory*
  Supplies: Unsupported standing acquired through transmission or visible process.
  Ontology-laundering boundary: Authority laundering changes apparent standing; ontology laundering changes the interpretive substrate.
- **Adjacent work:** *Governance Coverage Gaps*
  Supplies: Paths that escape declared mediation and evidence.
  Ontology-laundering boundary: A semantic change can travel through an uncovered path without proving intent to launder.

A diagnostic record should bind:

$$\begin{aligned} L = (&predecessor, successor, changed_anchors, proposer,\\ &authority, rationale, evidence, counterevidence,\\ &beneficiaries, burdens, compatibility, contest, effects,\\ &alternatives, classification) \end{aligned}.$$

The record must preserve the old and new ontology even where compatibility is impossible or the predecessor was harmful. Reviewers should distinguish legitimate revision, contested revision, under-governed drift, negligent distortion, strategic-laundering candidate, and separately evidenced deliberate laundering. Incentive, asymmetry, or favorable outcome can trigger inquiry but cannot prove intent.

The diagnostic must be safe against recursive misuse. Calling criticism laundering, freezing an outdated ontology, requiring harmful disclosure, or treating minority dissent as inherently correct are themselves failure modes. Findings require exact custody, reviewer disagreement, privacy boundaries, appeal, revision, and a proportional reputational claim ceiling.

The universal GSM can type `REPLACES_SEMANTIC_ANCHOR`, `CHANGES_ADMISSIBILITY_RULE`, `USES_PROXY_FOR_OUTCOME`, `AUTHORIZED_AS_ONTOLOGY_REVISION`, `OBSCURES_AFFECTED_PARTY`, `BURDENS_UNDER_NEW_CLASS`, `PRESERVES_COMPATIBILITY_MAP`, `CONTESTED_BY_ALTERNATE_EXPLANATION`, `CLASSIFIED_AS_UNDER_GOVERNED_DRIFT`, and `REVISED_AFTER_APPEAL`. These relations preserve analysis without turning the diagnostic into an oracle.

This integration establishes four editorial commitments: classify the work as a consequential semantic-change diagnostic; adopt the full diagnostic record; require intent-neutral classification, alternate explanations, and proportional

claim ceilings; and govern the diagnostic's own ontology, privacy, contest, appeal, and revision paths.

Proposed Change, Propagation, and Effect

The fixed-seed comparison with the Identity Spine Doctrine, Governance Coverage Gaps, receipt reasoning, and GCNL turns an ontology-change diagnosis into a traceable transition:

$$O = (GCNL_proposal, predecessor, diff, identity_decision, \\ standing, propagation, coverage, effects, receipts, \\ classification, appeal)$$

GCNL can express a proposed term, definition, classification, proxy, admissibility rule, authority reference, and expected effect while preserving ambiguity and residual meaning. A well-formed proposal is not legitimate revision and does not imply laundering. The Identity Spine governs admission, linkage, split, merge, fork, supersession, and refusal under exact predecessor custody.

Coverage analysis asks whether the successor and its burden or compatibility rules reached every consequential dependent. Uncovered prompts, indexes, compiled views, enforcement structures, or external consumers can create silent mixed ontologies. Propagation failure may be negligence, drift, constraint conflict, or deliberate strategy; the record should not infer intent from the effect alone.

Receipts should bind the proposal, diff, decision, propagation attempts, observed effects, counterevidence, classification, and appeal. They preserve what the process claimed and observed without making the ontology correct, the authority legitimate, or the laundering diagnosis true.

The universal GSM can type
`PROPOSES_ONTOLOGY_CHANGE_IN_GCNL`,
`DIFFS_SEMANTIC_PREDECESSOR`, `ADJUDICATES_IDENTITY_CHANGE`, `PROPAGATES_SUCCESSOR_BINDING`,
`DISCOVERS_MIXED_ONTOLOGY`, `RECEIPTS_LAUNDERING_CLASSIFICATION`,
and
`APPEALS_SEMANTIC_CHANGE_FINDING`.

This randomized review establishes four editorial commitments: adopt the proposal-to-effect ontology transition; use GCNL as a non-authorizing proposal surface; require propagation coverage and mixed-ontology detection; and keep receipts and observed effects below intent and legitimacy findings.

A Burden- and Effect-Aware Ontology-Change Docket

Seven downstream uses position Ontology Laundering as an adversarial diagnostic rather than the positive identity protocol. Governance Incentive Engineering applies it to metric and category capture. Governance Coverage Gaps finds

semantic-change paths outside declared gates. GCNL exposes a proposal diff. Identity Spine supplies positive admission and propagation. Receipt reasoning preserves the transition without deciding the diagnosis. The Suppression Paradox treats category change as one way a concern becomes unspeakable. *Everything Is a Compiler* keeps Ontology Laundering as a specific diagnosis rather than absorbing it into a broad metaphor.

The case docket is:

$$\begin{aligned} O = (&predecessor, proposal, diff, proposer, authority,\\ &changed_claims, changed_burdens, beneficiaries,\\ &alternatives, propagation, coverage, effects, notice,\\ &contest, evidence, explanations, classification, remedy,\\ &appeal) \end{aligned} \quad .$$

The default inquiry should remain intent-neutral. A consequential semantic change may be legitimate revision, error, drift, negligence, capture, coercion, strategic ambiguity, or deliberate laundering. Observed benefit or burden alone does not identify intent. The classification must preserve competing explanations and state what evidence could change the result.

Burden propagation is as important as term propagation. A successor ontology can preserve labels while shifting who must prove, pay, disclose, qualify, appeal, or bear risk. Review should compare predecessor and successor decisions over representative cases, including minority and refusal cases. Remedies may include rollback, fork, coexistence, quarantine, compensating interpretation, re-adjudication, or prospective correction; none should rewrite the historical transition.

The universal GSM can type
`PROPOSES_ONTOLOGY_CHANGE`, `SHIFTS_SEMANTIC_BURDEN`,
`BENEFITS_ACTOR_UNDER_SUCCESSOR`, `PRESERVES_COMPETING_EXPLANATION`,
`ESCAPES_IDENTITY_GATE`, `PROPAGATES_MIXED_ONTOLOGY`, `REMEDIATES_WITHOUT_HISTORY_REWRITE`, and
`APPEALS_LAUNDERING_CLASSIFICATION`.

This reverse-dependency review establishes four editorial commitments: adopt the burden- and effect-aware docket; preserve intent-neutral competing explanations; test predecessor and successor decisions over affected cases; and make remedy, appeal, and historical custody first-class.

15. Counterevidence and Failure Modes

The theory should be narrowed or rejected where: (1) ordinary semantic change is relabeled laundering; (2) political or value disagreement is treated as objective decoupling; (3) intent is inferred from outcome; (4) one observer claims privileged access to reality; (5) semantic anchors are treated as direct truth; (6) historical

terminology is frozen despite new evidence; (7) compatibility is impossible for a necessary correction; (8) secrecy has a legitimate privacy or security basis; (9) independent witnesses share hidden dependencies; (10) transparency is mistaken for comprehension; (11) consensus is treated as inherently corrupt; (12) minority disagreement is treated as inherently correct; (13) procedural evidence is dismissed rather than bounded; (14) model use is treated as model laundering; (15) proxy use is treated as metric substitution without an outcome test; (16) statistical choices are condemned without domain analysis; (17) synthetic data is treated as falsification despite clear labeling and validation; (18) benefit is treated as proof of capture; (19) asymmetry follows legitimate risk differences; (20) authority concentration is necessary but reviewable; (21) the old ontology was itself harmful or false; (22) the new ontology improves external outcomes; (23) the risk vector hides value judgments in weights; (24) reviewers cannot agree above chance; (25) the classifier absorbs every counterexample; (26) receipts are mistaken for truth; (27) GMB inclusion is treated as endorsement; (28) lexical change is mistaken for anchor replacement; (29) the civilization-scale hypothesis lacks bounded data; (30) alternate causal models fit better; (31) accusations create reputational harm beyond the evidence; or (32) the framework cannot outperform ordinary change governance and conflict-of-interest analysis.

Diagnose Strategic Anchor Change Without Criminalizing Disagreement

Public orientation

Ontology laundering names a specific adversarial pattern: the semantic substrate used to judge conduct changes so strategic behavior becomes legitimate in appearance while reality coupling and contradiction permeability deteriorate. The framework does not classify ordinary disagreement, conceptual innovation, democratic revision, or institutional learning as corruption.

Adversarial tests

1. **Legitimate-evolution attack.** A necessary conceptual correction is mislabeled laundering because it challenges incumbents. The diagnostic must test authority, evidence, effects, and openness to contradiction.
2. **Partisan-accusation attack.** Opponents use the label to delegitimize each other without a bounded docket. Claims require exact before/after anchors and behavioral consequences.
3. **Consensus-as-proof attack.** Broad adoption is treated as legitimacy, or minority status as evidence of laundering. Consensus and warrant remain separate.
4. **Anchor-selection attack.** The analyst chooses a favorable historical baseline. Baseline authority, date, alternatives, and prior defects must be explicit.
5. **Intent-overreach attack.** Harmful semantic drift is assumed deliberate

without evidence. Strategic intent, negligence, emergence, and ordinary error are distinct findings.

6. **Behavior-gap attack.** Language changes but conduct does not, or conduct changes without ontology revision. The theory's causal pathway must be tested rather than presumed.
7. **Power-asymmetry attack.** Official records appear stable while affected people cannot contest categories. Contradiction permeability includes access and remedy.
8. **Cross-domain overreach.** A diagnostic from one institutional setting is applied to science, law, medicine, culture, or software without domain law and evidence.

Claim and evidence ceiling

The paper offers a falsifiable diagnostic for consequential semantic change under strategic pressure. It does not determine political truth, legal corruption, scientific validity, motive, or institutional legitimacy by itself. Ontology change is neither presumptively corrupt nor presumptively benign.

Any concrete institutional claim requires exact records, authorized baselines, affected-party evidence, behavioral measures, alternative explanations, current domain sources, and qualified review. Internal corpus examples establish the analytic form only. No external research was added in this pass.

Reader-facing consequence

The public question is whether the categories used to judge action were changed through an accountable, evidence-responsive process - or changed so that the same conduct could pass while objections became harder to express or hear.

17. Conclusion

Ontology laundering names a real candidate danger: a system can preserve procedure while changing the meanings by which procedure, evidence, authority, and failure are judged. The phrase is valuable only if it does not become its own semantic weapon.

The revised framework therefore places the burden on exact change custody, bounded correspondence, independent constraint, competing explanations, asymmetric-effect analysis, contradiction, appeal, and revision. It distinguishes legitimate correction from drift, negligence, strategic opacity, and deliberate deception. It permits inconclusive findings.

The central constitutional demand is not that meanings never change. It is that consequential semantic change remain visible enough to contest, evidence, compare, and revise before continuity of language is mistaken for continuity of obligation.

Reference and Verification Note

No external source was searched in this pass. Further evidentiary strengthening requires authorized primary-source and empirical review of institutional change, ontology and classification governance, measurement and proxy failure, scientific and statistical practice, model risk, consensus formation, regulatory capture, conflict of interest, due process, privacy, and the specific case domains chosen for illustration.

Realization Scope and Evidence Boundary

This successor makes the paper's stage boundary explicit. It narrows claims rather than manufacturing missing evidence: a stage named as context is not thereby claimed as implemented, validated, or complete.

- **Possibility Space.** The present paper does not claim a complete possibility space treatment. That stage remains successor work and cannot be inferred from the architecture described here.

Corpus-Wide Reference Positioning

This paper argues that institutions depend on revisable semantic anchors: definitions, classifications, measures, precedents, evidentiary rules, and authority relations that connect claims to observation and consequence. Its nearest external comparison fields are semantic, provenance, governance. The sources in [E1], [E2], [E3], [E4], [E5], [E6], [E7] are cited as predecessor literature, adjacent standards, or counterpressure - not as evidence that they caused the Ableman framework or that they validate its novel claims. The comparison isolates where established work already supplies provenance, formal assurance, institutional constraint, empirical method, or engineering practice, and where this paper adds a distinct claim about admissibility, authority, semantic custody, or governed realization.

Within the Ableman corpus, the highest-priority current cross-links are [A1], [A2], [A3], [A4], [A5], [A6], [A7]. These are links among separately custodied works, not silent identity mergers. Their role is to expose mutual dependencies, terminology collisions, and places where a reader should traverse the corpus before treating this paper as self-sufficient.

Reference-pass counterevidence and limit search

The pass applied the following pressure tests: Formal vocabularies and graph links make commitments explicit but cannot by themselves establish correct identity, shared interpretation, or lossless translation between contexts. A complete provenance graph can faithfully record a false or unauthorized process; provenance is evidence about lineage, not automatic truth or legitimacy. A written constitution can legitimate domination as easily as constrain it unless amendment, participation, enforcement, and appeal remain effective in practice.

These limits are not generic disclaimers: they identify the assumptions that a later empirical, formal, or implementation review must try to break.

Reference-pass influence and novelty boundary

No newly added external source is asserted to be a documented authorial influence unless the predecessor source already said so. `Predecessor` means earlier relevant work;

`adjacent` means a useful comparison; `standard` means an interoperability or assurance baseline; and `counterevidence` marks work that narrows or pressures a claim. Novelty therefore remains a reviewable, claim-level question rather than an inference from a low similarity score or an absent citation.

References

External scholarship, standards, and prior art

[**E1**] Richard Cyganiak, David Wood, and Markus Lanthaler, eds. *RDF 1.1 Concepts and Abstract Syntax*. W3C Recommendation, 25 February 2014. https://www.w3.org/TR/rdf11-concepts/ **Relationship:** Adjacent graph data model and identity baseline.

[**E2**] Alistair Miles and Sean Bechhofer, eds. *SKOS Simple Knowledge Organization System Reference*. W3C Recommendation, 18 August 2009. https://www.w3.org/TR/skos-reference **Relationship:** Adjacent standard for concepts, labels, schemes, notes, and semantic mappings.

[**E3**] W3C OWL Working Group. *OWL 2 Web Ontology Language Document Overview*, Second Edition. W3C Recommendation, 11 December 2012. https://www.w3.org/TR/owl2-overview/ **Relationship:** Adjacent formal ontology standard used to compare declared semantics and inference commitments.

[**E4**] Mark D. Wilkinson et al. "The FAIR Guiding Principles for Scientific Data Management and Stewardship." *Scientific Data* 3, 2016, 160018. DOI: 10.1038/sdata.2016.18. https://doi.org/10.1038/sdata.2016.18 **Relationship:** Predecessor stewardship principles for findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reuse.

[**E5**] Peter Gardenfors. *Conceptual Spaces: The Geometry of Thought*. MIT Press, 2000. mitpress.mit.edu source **Relationship:** Predecessor geometric treatment of concepts; cited as comparison, not as validation of the paper's manifold terminology.

[**E6**] W3C. *PROV-O: The PROV Ontology*. W3C Recommendation, 30 April 2013. https://www.w3.org/TR/prov-o/ **Relationship:** Adjacent provenance standard; it models entities, activities, and agents, but does not by itself establish the paper's stronger authority or standing claims.

[**E7**] Santiago Torres-Arias et al. “in-toto: Providing Farm-to-Table Guarantees for Bits and Bytes.” *28th USENIX Security Symposium*, 2019, pp. 1393-1410. usenix.org source **Relationship:** Predecessor supply-chain lineage system used for comparison; no influence claim is made unless the source head already documents one.

Ableman corpus

[**A1**] Adam Ableman. *Meaning as Binding.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-5F976917F0B283EA`;
source SHA-256
`A470D1A0B9ED7C3CEAB6BB88BE4B642A2BA36427447F787764329FD574DA0C97`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A2**] Adam Ableman. *Governed Meaning Base (GMB).* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-D95CCC4FB7B58BFB`;
source SHA-256
`A3B62E50F8BEE125FDAE0D38C2839AFD1CCC138296268BF93217481E38AA48EA`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A3**] Adam Ableman. *Semantic Manifold Topology.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity `PAPER.PUB.20257244`;
source SHA-256
`B8F28CC652A73A3EE4CF6FD0E23C1ABC922A6660319B2FB4CC1CCAAA606EC64A`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A4**] Adam Ableman. *Global Term Key: Identity Primitives in Governed Knowledge Systems.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-358AC09F5A13587E`;
source SHA-256
`AFB29CFCB4B58A78B79709AD453CEE9088CCB2AE40F30A70260F1B54F5160579`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A5**] Adam Ableman. *Semantic Legitimacy Before Context.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-091E34BA93992CE4`;
source SHA-256
`DEB7626CE1AB54F4B541347DCC3C4E14DC4F682230ACCCE1A93D1D536A50C44C`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A6**] Adam Ableman. *Reasoning by Way of Receipts.* Ableman Corpus current

edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-04E427F6F4D94454;
source SHA-256
AF86A66CCD6A103DD75208500AE99148911A6453B6DFDF36A954279F21AB8489.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A7**] Adam Ableman. *The Epistemic Lineage Engine.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-E0EC3DC7EABF5060;
source SHA-256
CDD74D9AFAB6532645E68F7F6C9F0F7A9E472D9B8E717290522566FF8DC01F11.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

Editorial source notes retained from predecessor

The entries below are corpus-internal comparison and dependency sources. Their inclusion does not establish external validation of this paper's empirical, safety, novelty, or performance claims.

Adam Ableman *Semantic Debt.* Zenodo, 2026. doi:10.5281/zenodo.21111666

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Corpus source and companion formats: https://github.com/AblemanMosaic/ableman-corpus
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DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.23848098